

Galicia Property Buyer's Checklist

25 questions to ask before you make an offer

on a rural property in Galicia or Asturias

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Buying a rural property in Galicia or Asturias is one of the most rewarding — and most complex — purchases you can make. The combination of unfamiliar legal processes, a different building culture, and properties that have often been neglected for decades means the risks are real.

This checklist will not replace a professional survey or legal advice — but it will help you ask the right questions before you commit. Work through it at every viewing. If a seller cannot answer these questions, that is information too.

If you need independent guidance at any stage — pre-purchase, during planning, or through a renovation — I am available for remote consultancy from £150 per session.

STRUCTURAL & CONDITION

Structure

01 Are the external walls structurally sound?

Look for bulging, cracking, or separation at corners. In granite rubble masonry, check for missing mortar, displaced stones, or signs of movement.

02 Is the roof watertight and in good condition?

Inspect for missing or broken tiles, sagging ridge lines, or signs of water ingress in the upper floors or loft space.

03 Are the timber floor structures intact?

Traditional Galician houses use timber joists. Check for rot, insect damage, and deflection — especially ground floor beams near external walls.

04 Is there visible damp or rising moisture?

Look for tide marks, efflorescence (white salt deposits), or dark patches on internal stone walls, particularly at low level.

05 Are the internal partitions original or modified?

Non-original partitions can indicate previous uses, illegal works, or structural interference. Ask what was changed and when.

06 What is the condition of windows and external doors?

Galician winters are wet. Poorly sealed or rotten joinery means immediate cost. Factor in replacement if timber frames are failing.

07 Are there signs of previous or active subsidence?

Diagonal cracks from corners of openings, sticking doors or windows, and uneven floors can all indicate movement. Get a structural engineer if in doubt.

PLANNING & LICENCIAS

Planning

08 Is the property in a protected zone (PEPRI, BIC, rural protection)?

Many rural Galician properties are in zones with significant restrictions on external alterations. Confirm the planning classification before assuming you can change the facade or roof form.

09 What licencia type is required for your intended works?

Minor works (obra menor) vs. major works (obra mayor) have very different timescales and costs. A full rehabilitation is almost always obra mayor and requires a full project signed by an arquitecto.

10 Has the property had previous unlicensed works?

Unauthorised construction is common in rural Galicia. Confirm any additions or alterations are reflected in the escritura and catastro — if they are not, they may need to be legalised before sale.

11 Is the property in a flood zone or area of environmental protection?

Check SNCZI (Spanish flood risk mapping) and the local PGOM. Proximity to rivers, estuaries, or protected land can block certain works entirely.

12 What does the local PGOM say about this plot?

The Municipal Plan defines what can be built, extended, or changed on every plot. Ask your architect to check before making an offer — not after.

13 Are there any existing enforcement notices or unresolved planning issues?

Ask the seller and check with the local Concello. Outstanding issues transfer with the property and become your problem.

LEGAL & OWNERSHIP

Legal

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- 14 Does the escritura (title deed) match what you are buying?**
The escritura records the legal description of the property. Compare it carefully against the physical boundaries and the catastro. Discrepancies are common in rural Galicia.
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- 15 Is the catastral description accurate and up to date?**
The catastro is the Spanish land registry. Check the reference, surface area, and use classification at sede.catastro.gob.es. Outdated records may need correcting before mortgage or sale.
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- 16 Are the property boundaries clearly defined and agreed?**
Rural plots in Galicia often have informal or disputed boundaries. Confirm with the seller and, if possible, inspect the physical markers. Consider a topographic survey for larger plots.
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- 17 Is the property free of charges, mortgages, or embargoes?**
Request a nota simple from the Registro de la Propiedad. This shows any registered debts, mortgages, or restrictions on the property.
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- 18 Are there any shared ownership or inheritance complications?**
Inherited rural properties in Galicia are frequently co-owned between multiple family members. Confirm that all co-owners are party to the sale and that consents are in place.
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- 19 Is there legal access to the property from a public road?**
Rural properties sometimes rely on informal tracks or rights of way that are not legally registered. Confirm access is guaranteed — particularly if the plot is landlocked.
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- 20 Are there any rights of way, easements, or communal obligations on the land?**
Galician rural land can be subject to traditional communal rights (montes vecinales, servidumbres). Your notario should confirm these before completion.
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COST & BUDGET REALITY

Budget

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- 21 Have you obtained at least two contractor quotes for the works?**
Prices in rural Galicia vary significantly. Get at least two quotes from local contractors — and have an architect review them before signing anything.
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- 22 Have you budgeted for architect and aparejador fees?**
Any obra mayor requires a project signed by an arquitecto and supervision by an aparejador. Budget 8-12% of build cost for professional fees, plus IVA (21%).
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- 23 Have you accounted for the full cost of purchase?**
Beyond the asking price: ITP (property transfer tax, typically 10% in Galicia), notario fees, registro fees, and gestor costs. Budget an additional 12-14% on top of purchase price.
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- 24 Is there mains water, electricity, and sewage — or will connections be needed?**
Rural properties without mains connections can require significant investment. Confirm service availability and the cost of connection with the relevant utility companies before committing.
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- 25 Have you stress-tested your budget against a 20% cost overrun?**
Rural renovation in Spain almost always runs over budget. Unforeseen structural issues, material lead times, and contractor availability are common causes. If a 20% overrun would break the project, reconsider your numbers.
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Need guidance before you make an offer?

Book a 30-minute remote consultancy call — fixed fee, plain English, no obligation.

calendly.com/luka-lukamorrisarchitects/30min